

a problem required time and patience, and few had that. Another drawback for the fledgling OS. The lack of support seems to be the straw that broke the camel's back. Somewhere down the road, Linux was slowly forgotten.

A spruced up Linux arrives

Ubuntu – an African word which stands for mutual dependence, goodwill and help – was about to become a symbol of software freedom and expression. The first release was in October 2004. However, as it happens with every new product/service, it takes time to build reputation. By the beginning of 2006, Ubuntu began rising in popularity due to its promise of rolling out a new release every six months (which was very quick compared to Windows).

In addition, the fortune owned by Mark Shuttleworth (founder of Canonical, the company that builds and supports Ubuntu) was spent on free CD shipping. You could simply go to Ubuntu's website and with a few clicks and keyboard strokes, order a set of Ubuntu CDs at no cost. You didn't pay for the CDs and you definitely didn't pay for the shipping.

To top it all, Ubuntu popularised the idea of 'Live CDs'. You didn't have to install the OS to test it out. All you needed to do was boot from the CD and check how compatible your hardware was with the OS. If things worked well, you could run the installer, which lived on the desktop. In addition to all this, Ubuntu also offered an installer (called Ubiquity) which was pretty intelligent at making correct guesses about what you'd want. The installer simplified the most complicated of languages, enabling even non-technical users to install the OS.

It had one of the tightest communities with interesting and active forums (yes, way before stack exchange even arrived on the scene) where help was readily available. With time, its ease of use only became more evident. You could nonchalantly type away a few lines on the once-dreaded terminal/shell/command-line or easily install software to play your music and movies in no time.

At the same time, OpenSuSE, Fedora, Gentoo etc. were also growing, however Ubuntu was light years ahead of them. Despite users being at loggerheads with one another in regards to what they wanted in the operating system, the final distro satisfied everyone. The community was somehow able to bring coherence to the chaos. One of the biggest reasons Ubuntu was getting so much attention was because it was based on Debian. This meant that the package manager in use, viz. APT was particularly intelligent and